FIRST CUSTOMER

First Customer — 10 Days to Your First Paying Customers — Day 2: Finding the First Buyers: Networks, Communities, and Signals

Study guide · Self-study

10 Days to Your First Paying Customers · Day 2: Finding the First Buyers: Networks, Communities, and Signals

How to Use This Guide

This is your guide for Day 2 of 10 Days to Your First Paying Customers. You work alone, at your own pace, inside your own business. Read a section, then stop and write. The blank lines are for your answers, not for neatness. Keep this guide open next to your contact list, your saved community threads and your notes from Day 1. Your target customer and buying trigger from Day 1 are the filter for everything here: a name, a community or a signal only counts if it sits behind that trigger.

- Block 30 to 45 minutes per section. Write your own answers before you read the model answers at the end.
- Today you find the people to contact; Day 3 covers what to say in the first seconds.
- Keep one page open for names and one for signals. You will use both in later days.

> **NOTES**
>
> A common mistake is to start collecting names before you have read Day 1 again. Ten minutes of rereading your target customer saves an hour of list building.

Today's Objectives (KASU)

This guide has one objective of each kind. Read them now, then return to them at the end and mark which ones you met.

- Knowledge: You will know the three source types for first buyers (warm network, communities, buying signals) and how to tell a signal of a trigger from a signal of general interest.
- Attitude: You will treat outreach as an invitation, not a pitch. Your job is to earn the next minute, not to sell in the first one.
- Skill: You will be able to approach a warm contact, a community member and a triggered prospect without pitching, and redirect a conversation you have started toward a real conversation by following up.
- Upskill: You will run three real openings this week without pitching once, and log which of the three source types most often got you a reply.

> **NOTES**
>
> If you have ever written a long introductory message about your product, the Attitude line is the one to watch today.

Three Places First Buyers Are Already Standing

First buyers are not hidden. They are in three places, and each place changes how you approach. The first place is your warm network: people who already know you, trust you a little, and will take your message. The second is communities: groups, forums, marketplaces and local gatherings where your buyers already talk about the problem you solve. The third is signals: public events that show a

trigger has fired. Your Day 1 work told you what the trigger is. Today you find who is standing next to it.

The psychology matters here. People do not buy because you found them. They buy because the moment is right and they feel safe enough to keep talking. A warm contact opens your message because your name is familiar. Cognitive ease applies: familiar names feel safer and are processed faster. A community member reads your post because it sounds like the group's language, not an advertisement. A triggered buyer responds because your reason is about their event, not your offer.

Write your own version of this list.

Warm names I already have: _____

Communities where my buyers already talk: _____

Signals that show my buying trigger has fired: _____

> **NOTES**
>
> If a source type gives you nothing after ten minutes, move on. This is a mapping exercise, not a research project.

Warm Networks: Map Before You Message

Most founders skip their network because it feels awkward. The way out is to map first and message second. List every person who knows you by name and could plausibly know, work with or introduce you to your target customer. Then note who introduced whom. You are looking for paths of one or two steps, not a hundred names.

Buyer psychology: a referral from someone the buyer trusts works as social proof before you have said anything. The buyer assumes you are safe because a trusted person spent time on you. That carries far more weight than any claim you make. Your network is not charity. It is a trust shortcut you have already earned. Use it honestly: ask permission before naming anyone.

B2B worked example. It is an example:

Practice example: a founder runs a scheduling tool for small clinics. She maps her network and finds a former colleague who now manages a three-clinic group. She does not pitch. She asks her contact whether an introduction makes sense and why.

B2C worked example. It is an example:

Practice example: a maker of custom children's furniture maps parents in her building, her child's activity group and a neighbor who teaches at a preschool.

Asking your network is easier when you treat it as information gathering, not a favor. Ask for one of three things: an opinion, an introduction, or a question they can answer from experience. Never lead with your offer.

Buyer psychology: a warm contact is more likely to answer because of commitment and consistency. If they have said yes to a small thing before, they are more likely to say yes again. So start small. The

other factor is loss aversion: people protect relationships. An ask that is easy to decline keeps the relationship safe for later.

Worked example. It is an example:

Practice example: "Hi Ben, it is Alex. I am talking to small clinic managers about their scheduling headaches. Who do you know who runs one? If this is a bad moment, just say so. What do you think they struggle with most?"

Reflection: write one real message you will send today.

Message: ____

- Name, how you know them, who they might know.
- Permission asked before using anyone's name.
- One introduction request per person, with the reason stated.
- One clear ask.
- An easy exit.
- A thank-you whether or not they help.

> **NOTES**
>
> The mistake is messaging everyone at once with the same long paragraph. Fewer, warmer, specific requests outperform volume here.
>
> If someone declines to help, say thank you and ask if you may check in another time. That is how a future introduction stays possible.

Communities: Enter as a Member, Not a Billboard

Online and local communities are where buyers discuss the problem in their own words. You are looking for forums, groups, marketplace categories, professional associations, newsletters and recurring meetups. Choose two or three where your Day 1 customer actually is, then read before you post. Spend a week answering questions without mentioning your offer.

Buyer psychology: people in groups guard against people who take without giving. Reciprocity is the reason this works: help first, and people become willing to help you. The other force is liking. Familiarity and shared language make a message feel like it belongs. A post that sounds like an ad is treated as noise and often removed.

B2B worked example. It is an example:

Practice example: a founder selling a reporting add-on for accounting teams joins two practitioner groups and answers three questions about month-end close before posting anything about his tool.

B2C worked example. It is an example:

Practice example: a running coach joins a local runners' group, shows up to two Saturday runs and offers one free pacing session to the group rather than posting a discount.

Communities have their own rhythm. Each has a norm, sometimes written and sometimes not. Your first action is to read the last fifty posts and notice how people ask and answer. Then contribute one helpful answer. Then, if the group allows it, ask one question that helps you learn.

Buyer psychology: people trust others who have already invested in the group. This is reciprocity at work, and also liking: shared language and shared effort create familiarity. A stranger who gives one real answer is treated as a member; one who posts an offer is treated as a nuisance.

Worked example. It is an example:

Practice example: a bookkeeping founder answers a question in a freelancers' group about separating business and personal accounts. She does not mention her service. Two days later, a member asks what she does. She replies briefly and offers a short call with an easy way to say no.

Reflection: what is one question you can answer this week in a community where your buyers gather?

Question: ____

- Do I read as a member or an advertiser here?
- What have I given this group before asking?
- Which rule of this group must I follow?

> **NOTES**
>
> One helpful answer in your own name is worth more than ten posts about your offer. Watch for the moment someone asks a question you can genuinely answer.
>
> If a community bans promotion, do not test the line. Be a member, build a name, and let people start conversations with you.

Buying Signals: Read the Trigger, Not General Interest

A buying signal is a public event that shows your Day 1 trigger has fired. Signal types differ by market. Common ones in B2B: a company hiring for a role connected to your problem, a funding announcement, a new location, a product launch, or a leadership change. Common ones in B2C: a move, a renovation, a new season, a life event, a reviewed purchase, or a public request for recommendations.

Buyer psychology: a signal reduces the buyer's perceived risk because the timing feels natural. The buyer who just hired a second receptionist is already thinking about scheduling. Your message arrives as relevant, not random. Contrast that with a message sent because you need sales. The buyer can tell the difference, and the irrelevant message confirms that you are selling, not helping.

B2B worked example. It is an example:

Practice example: a company posts three openings for warehouse coordinators in one month. That fits a trigger for a training founder who works with warehouse teams.

B2C worked example. It is an example:

Practice example: a neighborhood group thread asks for a trustworthy painter before a family moves in next month.

A signal tells you the timing may be right. Before you act, check three things. Does the signal match my Day 1 trigger? Is it recent? Is it public and appropriate to mention? If all three are yes, reach out using the opener you will learn on Day 3, and say what you saw.

Buyer psychology: relevance lowers threat. A buyer who sees a message about their own event feels seen rather than targeted. A buyer who sees a generic message feels processed. The difference is not effort; it is specificity.

Worked example. It is an example:

Practice example: a small bakery posts that it is opening a second counter. A founder who sells packaging with a short-run minimum writes: "Hi Lena, this is Jo with Cedar Packaging. I saw you are opening a second counter. If this is a bad time, just say so. What is your plan for packaging at the new site?"

Reflection: which signal have you seen this week that matches your trigger?

Signal: ____

- The signal I saw: ____
- The Day 1 trigger it matches: ____
- Why this is about the buyer, not me: ____
- Recency matters.
- Relevance to the trigger matters more.
- If it looks like a stretch, wait for a better one.

> **NOTES**
>
> Not every signal is ready to be used. A signal that fits only if you stretch your trigger is usually no signal at all.
>
> The mistake is reacting to every signal. Two strong, well-timed openings beat twenty weak ones.

Apply It in Your Role

You run your own business, so this guide only matters if it changes today's work. Choose one action from each source. Build one warm list. Join one community correctly. Watch for one signal type. Then prepare your openings in your own words, ready for the opening structure on Day 3. You do not need a perfect list. You need five real openings this week.

Use this simple count.

Warm names written: ____

Communities joined and read: ____

Signals watched: ____

Openings sent: _____

Total: _____

> **NOTES**
>
> If your total for openings sent is zero, that is the only number worth fixing today.

What Would You Say?

Write your answer to each situation before reading the model answers at the end. Your words should sound like you. The principle matters more than the exact wording.

1. A former colleague who knows many small clinic managers has not replied to your last two messages. Write one short message that asks for an opinion, with an easy way to decline.

Your answer: _____

2. You have just joined a forum for independent gym owners. Write your first post, which must give something useful and must not mention your offer.

Your answer: _____

3. A local framing company posts a job for a project manager. That matches your trigger for a software tool. Write the first message.

Your answer: _____

> **NOTES**
>
> Read the model answers only after your own writing is done. Comparing your draft to a model is how you learn what was missing.

Key Takeaways

You now have three maps: your warm network, your communities and your buying signals. Keep them. Your first job on every approach is to earn the next minute, not to pitch. The opener that does that properly is the subject of Day 3, so today you map, you give first, and you reach out without selling.

- Warm network: ask for an opinion or an introduction before you mention your offer.
- Communities: give first, read the norms, let people ask you.
- Signals: reach out only when the signal matches your trigger and is recent.
- No pitch in the first message. Earn the next minute.
- Day 3 covers the opener itself: how to say who you are and give one true, specific reason before the call goes further.

NOTES

Write the three source types on a sticky note and keep it where you make calls.

Quiz

Answer all five questions. Choose one answer for each. The answer key is at the end.

1. What is the main purpose of giving an easy way to decline in a first message?

   A. To make it easy for the person to say not now
   B. To show how much you know about your product
   C. To create a sense of urgency
   D. To get a meeting booked on the first call

2. Which of the following is the best example of a buying signal that matches a Day 1 trigger?

   A. A company posts a generic holiday greeting
   B. A company announces it is opening a second location next month
   C. Your competitor launches a new website
   D. A friend says they might need your service someday

3. In a community group, what should you do before posting anything about your offer?

   A. Ask the group administrator to pin your offer
   B. Send the same message to as many members as possible
   C. Read the group norms and contribute a helpful answer
   D. Wait until someone complains about a problem

4. Why does a warm introduction from a trusted contact work better than a cold message?

   A. Because the contact is obligated to introduce you
   B. Because the buyer assumes you are safe due to a trusted person's recommendation
   C. Because warm introductions always lead to a sale
   D. Because cold messages are frowned upon in every market

5. A former colleague has not replied to your last two messages. What is the best next step?

   A. Send a third message that is longer and more detailed
   B. Give up on the contact completely
   C. Send a short message asking for an opinion with an easy way to decline
   D. Call them repeatedly until they answer

Upskill Challenge

Your Upskill challenge for this week has three parts. Do them in your own business, with your own prospects. Write down what happens.

- Map ten warm contacts and ask two of them for an opinion or an introduction, with an easy way to decline.
- Join one community where your buyers gather. Contribute three helpful answers before you mention your offer.
- Watch for three signals that match your Day 1 trigger. Send one first message that says what you saw and why it is relevant to them. Do not pitch.
- After each opening, note which part you skipped or rushed under pressure, such as the easy exit: ____
- What happened after your three openings: ____

> **NOTES**
>
> The goal is not replies. The goal is to run the approach cleanly, even when you feel nervous.

Model Answers

These are examples, not scripts. Use the principle behind each answer and write in your own voice.

- 1. "Hi Ben, it is Alex. I am trying to understand how small clinic managers handle scheduling. If this is a bad time, just say so. What do you think is their biggest headache right now?" This works because it asks for an opinion rather than a favor, gives an easy exit and stays a question rather than a pitch.
- 2. "Hi all, I run a small gym and have struggled with late cancellations. Here is a reminder text I have been using that cut no-shows by about a third. Happy to share the exact wording if it is useful." This works because it gives value first and lets the group ask for more.
- 3. "Hi Tom, this is Sam from Northline. I saw you are hiring a project manager. If this is a bad time, just say so. How are you planning to coordinate schedules across both sites?" This works because the reason is true, specific and about the buyer's event, the exit is easy, and the question does the rest.
- Quiz answers:
- 1. A. People stay when they know they can leave. When they feel pushed, they push back.
- 2. B. An expansion announcement is a public event that matches a common trigger. Holiday greetings and competitor moves are not signals of your buyer's trigger.
- 3. C. Read the group norms and give one helpful answer before anything else. People trust members who contribute.
- 4. B. A trusted recommendation works as social proof before you speak. It does not create an obligation, and it does not guarantee a sale.
- 5. C. A short, low-threat message asking for an opinion with an easy exit keeps the relationship safe. Longer messages and repeated calls add pressure.

> **NOTES**
>
> Notice that none of the models includes a product description. That is the point.

References

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